Foreign Policymaking (EA)

Political Science — Master Notes · by Jakob V. Stangel

Required reading: Ashbee, E. & Hurst, S. (2020), "*The Trump foreign policy record and the concept of transformational change*," **Global Affairs 6(1): 5–19 · Putnam, R. (1988),** "*Diplomacy and Domestic Politics: The Logic of Two-Level Games*," **International Organization 42(3): 427–460 (to p.435).** · Lecturer: **Eddie Ashbee.** *(Putnam is CBS-library-only, not in the folder — the two-level-game section below is built from the deck + the standard framework; the win-set detail is the assigned part.)*

Theme of the lecture. The IR theory lectures (I–IV) work mostly at the **international / state level** and treat what goes on *inside* a state as a "**black box.**" This session **opens the box:** foreign policy is shaped by **domestic** as well as international variables, and the two **interact** — theorised through **neoclassical realism**, **Foreign Policy Analysis (FPA)**, and Putnam's "**two-level game.**" The running case study is **US foreign policy since January 2017** — Trump and "Trumpism."

> ★ **The heart of the lecture:** foreign policy is **not** just a state responding to the international system — it is the **product of domestic politics interacting with international pressures.** IR's grand theories black-box the domestic; **FPA / neoclassical realism** open it, showing how **individuals, ideas, bureaucracies, interest groups and public opinion** shape policy. Putnam's **two-level game** models the interaction: a leader bargains **internationally (Level I)** and must get the deal **ratified at home (Level II)** at the same time. The **Trump** case tests whether a foreign-policy shift is "**transformational**" — a lasting change in **paradigm, interests, institutions and logics**.

The red thread. For any foreign-policy episode ask: *which domestic variables are in play, how do they interact with the international situation — and is the change **transformational** or just a passing shift?*

Key concepts / "modes" to use

- **The "black box"** — why grand IR theory sidelines domestic politics.
- **Foreign Policy Analysis (FPA) / neoclassical realism** — systemic pressures **filtered through** domestic intervening variables.
- **Domestic variables** — individuals · ideas/ideologies · bureaucratic cultures · interest groups & constituencies · public opinion (+ **salience**).
- **Transformational change** (Ashbee & Hurst) — a lasting shift in **paradigm · interests · institutions · logics**.
- **Embeddedness** — ideas rooted in supportive **interests + institutions** (weak embeddedness → only "proto-transformational").
- **Two-level game** (Putnam) — Level I (international bargaining) + Level II (domestic ratification); **win-sets**; the **Schelling conjecture**.

Opening the "black box" — why Foreign Policy Analysis? *(deck)*

Core: the main IR theories are **international- or state-level** — they largely **relegate or disregard** domestic processes, treating the state as a "**black box**" that responds to the system.

- **Structural realism (Waltz):** international relations are **anarchic**, trust is limited, so **any** state (autocracy *or* democracy) must **prioritise its own security & survival** and will act **if it has the capacities.** *(Domestic type barely matters.)*
- **Liberal internationalism (Ikenberry):** looks a little more inside — it cares about the **character of political *systems*** (democracies tend to avoid offensive wars — answerable to the public, tied by trade **interdependence**, cooperating through **IOs**; the tongue-in-cheek "**Golden Arches** theory" — no two countries with McDonald's fight). But it still doesn't examine **internal processes** closely.
- **Foreign Policy Analysis (FPA)** & **neoclassical realism** open the box: foreign policy = the **interaction of international structure *and* domestic processes** — not one or the other.

Neoclassical realism — the bridge

Core: **neoclassical realism** keeps realism's **systemic** starting point (relative power, anarchy) but says those pressures are **filtered through domestic "intervening variables"** — leaders' perceptions, state–society relations, institutions — before they become policy. *(This is the neoclassical row of the realism family: "structure pushes, but domestic politics filters the push.")* → so **the same international pressure produces different policies** in different states, depending on the domestic filter. This is the theoretical warrant for spending the rest of the lecture on **domestic variables.**

★ Domestic variables that shape foreign policy *(deck)*

Core: five families of domestic variable — each a lens, none sufficient alone.

Variable	What it captures	Watch-outs / examples
Individuals / core actors	the "**great man theory of history**" (Carlyle: "*the history of the world is but the biography of great men*") — leaders' beliefs, style, psychology	**Trump** (impulse control, short attention span). *But* focusing on individuals **neglects structural forces** (see below)
Ideas & ideologies ("belief systems")	the **paradigm** guiding policy — what problems/goals/instruments seem legitimate	Was Trump-I "standard Republican fare" (**Reagan's "peace through strength"**) or a genuine break? *(the debate the reading settles)*
Bureaucratic cultures & sub-cultures	agencies' standing operating cultures; **coalitions & factions** inside the executive	State Dept vs Defense vs intelligence — "trade hawks" vs finance factions under Trump
Interest groups & constituencies	**lobbying, campaigning, campaign contributions, the "revolving door"** — and geographic **constituencies** (e.g. rust-belt states)	note **instrumental power** (direct lobbying) vs **structural power** (business's leverage over investment/jobs)
Public opinion	mass attitudes constraining leaders (e.g. **Vietnam** disengagement blamed on unpopularity)	★ **salience:** except in **acute crisis or heavy losses**, public engagement with foreign policy is usually **LOW** (Durant & Diehl 1989)

- **The structural counterweight (deck):** an individual-only focus **underestimates context.** Trump's mercurial style was *enabled* by the **relative weakness of checks & balances** in the foreign-policy arena — plus deeper trends: **party polarisation**, **party homogenisation**, and a **populist shift.** *(Cf. **Truman (1945–53)** leading the US into international engagement — a mix of **individual** commitment + shifts in **economic elites** + **strategic** pressure from the USSR: several variables at once.)*

★ Case study — US foreign policy since 2017 *(Ashbee & Hurst 2020)*

The paradigm Trump inherited

Core: to judge whether Trump is a *break*, you must know what he broke *from*. US foreign policy ran on **Liberal Internationalism (LI)** — itself the product of the **1940s transformation** — which then fragmented.

- **Liberal Internationalism (LI)** — after WWII the US committed to **open-ended international engagement + global leadership**, building the **UN, IMF, World Bank, GATT, NATO** and a domestic **national-security state** (National Security Act 1947 → DoD, Joint Chiefs, NSC, CIA). *(This is the reading's model of a completed **transformation** — see below.)*
- **Fragmentation from the 1970s:** LI split. Some (mainly **Democrats**) rejected the **use of force**; another grouping (mainly **Republicans**) rejected LI's **cooperative** side → **militant / conservative internationalism** = **primacism** (US primacy, "hard" power used **unilaterally** or in **coalitions of the willing**, sidelining the UN/multilateralism) **but** keeping a **moral purpose** — faith in **democracy &**

freedom (Bush's Iraq war, democracy promotion, nation-building, regime change) and trade liberalisation. This paradigm **weakened from ~2006.**

- **2016 — MAGA:** a populist reaction to "**elite projects**" and perceived **US decline**, addressing both domestic and foreign policy.

Trump's first term (2017–21) — the populist-nationalist break

Core: Trump = **primacism + economic nationalism +** "**principled realism**" — i.e. conservative internationalism **minus the moral purpose.** The reading distils a **populist-nationalist paradigm** of **five propositions:**

1. **The nation is core** — defined by **ethnicity/culture**, not ideals/principles (Bannon: "a nation with a culture — and a reason for being").
2. **Zero-sum competition** — nations are locked in a **struggle for hegemony**; limited scope for cooperation (the 2017 National Security Strategy used "competition" **18 times**); the US has been "losing."
3. **Anti-"globalism"** — the nation & its people have suffered from **globalism** and global elites ("the party of Davos").
4. **Trade subordinated to the nation** — markets should serve national purposes; hostility to **NAFTA/TPP**; prefer **bilateral ("one-on-one") deals** where US preponderance wins; reject **multilateral** trade liberalisation.
5. **Moral vision abandoned** — no more Reagan's "shining city" or Bush's freedom agenda; **rejects regime change / democracy promotion** ("we are not here to lecture").

- **In practice:** challenging **China**; **transactionalism**; negotiations with **Russia & North Korea**; **unilateralism**; **burden-sharing** demands on allies; doubts about **collective security (NATO)**; **protectionism.**

★ Was it *transformational*? — the Ashbee & Hurst framework

Core: the paper's real contribution is a **precise definition of transformational change** (drawing on **Polanyi**, historical institutionalism, Skowronek). Transformational change = a **lasting** shift across **four** linked elements — not just dramatic-but-passing change.

Element	What must shift	LI (1940s) — the model	Trump (2017+) — the "first cut"
Paradigm	the framework of ideas/goals/instruments (Hall) — until new ideas become **"common sense"**	open-ended engagement & liberal world order	populist-nationalist paradigm (anti-globalism, bilateralism, no moral purpose) — **but only "common sense" to the base**
Interests	new interests grip power; **new coalitions** (Skowronek)	New-Deal coalition + "Wall Street" Republicans sideline isolationists	FP "establishment" & peak business **sidelined**; GOP base shifts to **non-college white workers**
Institutions	formal & informal institutional **re-ordering**	UN/IMF/NATO + the national-security state	withdrawals (**Paris, TPP, UNESCO, UN HR Council**), undermining the **WTO**, gutting the **State Dept**/IC — *but* core alliances **remain intact**
Logics	new **chains of events**/incentives that endure (path dependence)	enduring collective-security commitments	weakened trans-Atlanticism; allies edge toward **self-reliance**; TPP revived **without** the US

- ★ **The verdict:** applying the framework gives a **mixed picture** — the **beginnings of transformational change, but "incipient, partial and variegated."** The **ideational** shift is the most dramatic; institutional/interest shifts are real but **incomplete**; logics are hardest to read this early.

★ Embeddedness — why "proto-transformational"

Core: ideas only become a *lasting* transformation when they are **embedded** — i.e. **rooted in supportive *interests* and *institutions*** (so they outlive the leader). Trump's first-term primacism was **pursued inconsistently** and **weakly embedded** (he **marginalised** the national-security bureaucracy but did **not rebuild** it into a self-sustaining machine for the new paradigm) → only **"proto-transformational."**

- **Two reasons it may not stick (reading):** (1) **populism is a "thin" ideology** (Mudde) — a **crust** on top of other ideologies, so the administration could be pulled **back** toward conservative/militant internationalism; (2) the US remains **locked into** its key post-war security institutions.

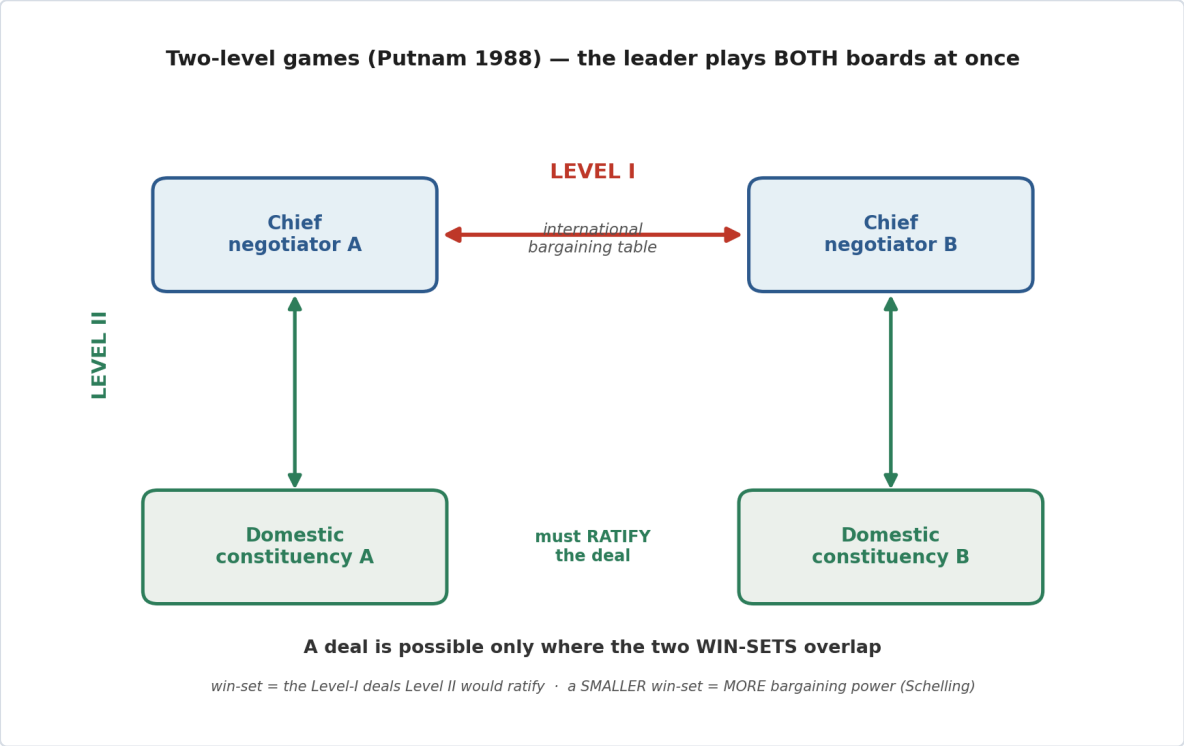
Second term (2025+) & the Democrats *(deck)*

- **Trump II / the GOP: no single guiding ideology** — pulled between rival **ideational clusters.** But some **constants ("floating ideas")** cut across the divisions: **support for Israel** (note the role of **religious conservatism** in the party), **disdain for Europe** + support for "patriotic" forces; **2026** sees growing divisions (e.g. **Iran**).
- **Democrats: no clear foreign-policy orientation**; Biden's "**alliance of democracies**" gained limited traction; continued **opposition to China** + **support for Ukraine**; increasingly **divided over Israel/Palestine (Gaza)** (DNC vs DSA); 2028 wide open.

★ How do domestic & international variables interact? — the two-level game *(Putnam 1988)*

Core: domestic and international variables clearly interact — but *on what terms?* (avoid analytical "**ad-hocery**"). Putnam's answer: an international negotiation is a **single game played simultaneously at two interconnected levels.**

- **Level I** = **bargaining between the negotiators** at the international table.
- **Level II** = **separate discussions inside each country** about whether to **ratify** what the negotiator brings home.
- The leader sits at **both boards at once**: a deal must be **struck internationally** *and* **ratifiable domestically.**



How to read it. The key concept is the **win-set** = *the set of all Level-I deals that would win ratification at Level II.* Two consequences:

- **A deal is possible only where the two win-sets *overlap*** — bigger win-sets make agreement **more likely** (but risk a deal your public dislikes).
- **★ The Schelling conjecture (the counter-intuitive bit):** a **smaller** win-set can give a negotiator **more bargaining power** — "*I'd love to accept, but my parliament will never ratify that*" forces the other side to move. Being **tied down at home** is a **bargaining asset** abroad.
- **Defection:** a deal can fail through **voluntary** defection (a rational leader reneges) or **involuntary** defection (the leader *can't deliver* because ratification fails at home). → *domestic and international politics are **entangled**, not separate.*

Or does the balance *vary*? *(deck)*

Core: an alternative to "it's always a two-level game" is that the **weight** of domestic vs international variables **varies systematically** — by:

- **Time-period** — domestic variables matter **less in acute crisis** (power centralises, the public rallies).
- **State size** — **small states** may have **fewer foreign-policy options** (more constrained by the system).
- **Regime type** — **liberal democracies** are arguably **more exposed to domestic pressures** than illiberal/authoritarian states.
- **Policy arena** — some issues draw **much more domestic engagement** — most notably **trade.**

Cases & examples

- **The 1940s Liberal-Internationalism transformation.** Paradigm (global leadership) + interests (New-Deal/Wall-Street coalition) + institutions (UN/IMF/NATO + national-security state) + enduring logics. → *Illustrates: a **completed** transformational change — the model Trump is measured against.*
- **Trump-era US foreign policy (2017+).** Populist-nationalist paradigm, sidelined establishment, withdrawals from agreements, gutted State Dept — but intact alliances. → *Illustrates: "**incipient, partial and variegated**" transformation; **weak embeddedness** → proto-transformational.*
- **Vietnam disengagement.** Blamed on rising unpopularity — but note **salience** (opinion bites mainly under heavy losses). → *Illustrates: **public opinion** as a domestic variable, and its limits.*
- **Truman & international engagement (1945–53).** Individual commitment + elite shifts + USSR pressure. → *Illustrates: foreign policy as **several domestic + international variables interacting.***

Key terms

Term	Meaning
"Black box"	Grand IR theory treats the state's internal politics as unopened — inputs (system) → outputs (policy)
Foreign Policy Analysis (FPA)	The study of foreign policy as a product of domestic processes + international structure
Neoclassical realism	Systemic pressures **filtered through** domestic intervening variables (leaders, institutions)
Salience	How much the public actually attends to an issue (usually **low** for foreign policy)
Instrumental vs structural power	Direct lobbying vs business's leverage from control over investment/jobs
Transformational change	Lasting shift in **paradigm · interests · institutions · logics** (Ashbee & Hurst / Polanyi)
Embeddedness	Ideas rooted in supportive **interests + institutions** → they endure beyond the leader
Primacism	US **primacy**/preponderance as the organising aim of foreign policy
Two-level game (Putnam)	A negotiation played simultaneously at **Level I** (international) + **Level II** (domestic ratification)
Win-set	The set of Level-I deals that would be **ratified** at Level II; deals need **overlapping** win-sets
Schelling conjecture	A **smaller** win-set (tied hands at home) can mean **more** bargaining power abroad

Exam pointers

- Explain the "**black box**" critique and how **neoclassical realism / FPA** open it (systemic pressure **filtered through** domestic variables).
- List and apply the **five domestic variables** — and the **salience** caveat on public opinion.
- Define **transformational change** by its **four elements** (paradigm/interests/institutions/logics) and run it on **Trump** — verdict: "**incipient, partial and variegated**"; explain **embeddedness** and why Trump-I was only **proto-transformational.**
- Set out the **two-level game** (Level I/II, **win-sets**, the **Schelling conjecture**, voluntary vs involuntary defection).
- Give the **four ways the domestic–international balance may vary** (time/crisis, state size, regime type, policy arena — esp. **trade**).

Bridge. This lecture is the **hinge** between IR **theory** (I–IV) and real foreign-policy **practice**: the grand theories set the *international* stage, but **who a state actually is at home** — its leaders, ideas, bureaucracies, interests and publics — decides how it plays. The **two-level game** is the model of that interaction; **transformational change** is the yardstick for whether a shift will last.

★ Fun facts & memorable details (Foreign Policymaking)

> Sticky bits from the foreign-policymaking lecture.

- **The "Golden Arches" theory of peace:** no two countries that both have **McDonald's** had ever fought a war (a jokey stand-in for the liberal claim that **trade interdependence** deters war).
- "**The history of the world is but the biography of great men**" (Carlyle, 1840) — the **great-man theory** the lecture uses to *set up* why leaders alone aren't enough.
- **Tied hands are a bargaining chip:** Putnam/Schelling's counter-intuitive point — "*my parliament will never ratify that*" can win you a **better** deal. Weakness at home = strength abroad.
- **The 2017 US National Security Strategy used the word "competition" 18 times** — the reading's neat evidence of the zero-sum, nationalist paradigm shift.
- **A "hostile takeover":** a departing senior diplomat described Trump's first-year State Department — "*you decapitate the leadership, you compartmentalize the power centers, you engender fear and suspicion.*"
- **Populism is a "thin" ideology** (Mudde) — a **crust** on top of other ideologies, which is why Ashbee & Hurst call Trump-I only "**proto-transformational.**"
- **Japan revived the TPP *without* the US** after Trump pulled out — a real "changed logic": the world starts building around, not through, Washington.

PART III · THE EUROPEAN UNION AS A POLITICAL SYSTEM